
The Invisible College of Medicine in Jagiellonian Courts: The Network of Giovanni Manardo's Medical Letters

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Abstract

Giovanni Manardo (1462–1536), a Ferrarese physician and medical humanist, served at the Jagiellonian court in Buda between 1513 and 1518 as physician to King Vladislaus II and King Louis II. His *Epistolae medicales*, first printed at Ferrara in 1521 and expanded through later editions, transformed learned medical consultation into a publishable epistolary corpus. The research problem addressed here is how this corpus can be used to reconstruct the social and spatial conditions of medical knowledge exchange in East-Central Europe. Rather than treating the letters only as humanist texts or as isolated medical opinions, the paper models them as evidence for a courtly "invisible college" of medicine, shaped by patronage, recommendation, dynastic service, and selective access to expertise (Maclean 2008; Siraisi 2013).

The core data consist of Manardo's *Epistolae medicales*, with attention to their early manuscript circulation and printed witnesses from Ferrara, Paris, Strasbourg, Bologna, Lyon, and Basel between the 1521 and 1557. These witnesses are read alongside Jagiellonian court account books, diplomatic correspondence, and archival materials concerning Buda, Kraków, Vilnius, and Ferrara. The data extracted from these sources include named persons, places, offices, institutional affiliations, medical conditions, therapies, cited authorities, recommendations, and references to the movement of advice or objects. This combination of epistolary and administrative evidence situates Manardo's medical writing within the broader culture of Jagiellonian humanism and royal service (Pajorin 1972; Kiss 2022; Heitsch 2021).

Methodologically, the project combines historical philology with historical network analysis. The Latin text is processed through OCR, manually corrected, and encoded for multi-layer annotation. Named-entity recognition and controlled prosopographical identification are then used to construct a two-mode network linking persons and places. This network is projected into person-to-person and place-to-place layers in order to examine co-occurrence, mediation, and spatial clustering. Network visualisation and centrality measures are used cautiously, not as self-sufficient proof, but as instruments for source criticism and hypothesis formation in a fragmentary corpus (Ahnert et al. 2020). The same model also makes it possible to compare named correspondents with unnamed patients, patrons, and intermediaries, whose partial visibility is itself historically significant.

The study's main argument is that Manardo's letters preserve traces of a medical communication system in which access to learned advice depended on courtly position, trusted

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intermediaries, Latin literacy, and publication. The study offers a historically controlled model for analysing how medical authority, pathological concepts, and therapeutic recommendations could circulate between Italian university medicine and Jagiellonian political centres. Its broader contribution is twofold: it brings East-Central Europe more fully into the history of Renaissance medical humanism, and it demonstrates how network analysis can be applied to biased and unevenly surviving medical correspondence without losing sight of source survival, silence, and editorial self-fashioning.

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Keywords: Giovanni Manardo, Epistolae medicinales, Republic of Letters, Renaissance medical humanism, Jagiellonian courts, historical network analysis, digital humanities.